RAJASTHAN

ONE FOR KRISHNA

By Rohit Parihar



APPEASING THE SAINTS Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot and others with the protesting mahants of Bharatpur, July 31

The saints of Bharatpur had already been up in arms for 550 days against mining in the Adi-Badri and Kanakanchal hills, a range of not just ecological but also religious significance, before things really caught fire. On July 20, one of them, Baba Narayandas, climbed up a mobile tower and while officials were pleading with him to come down, another saint, Vijaydas, immolated himself. A fortnight earlier, a seer named Baba Hariboldas had threatened to stage this act of ultimate protest before the CM's house. Now one of them had gone and done it.

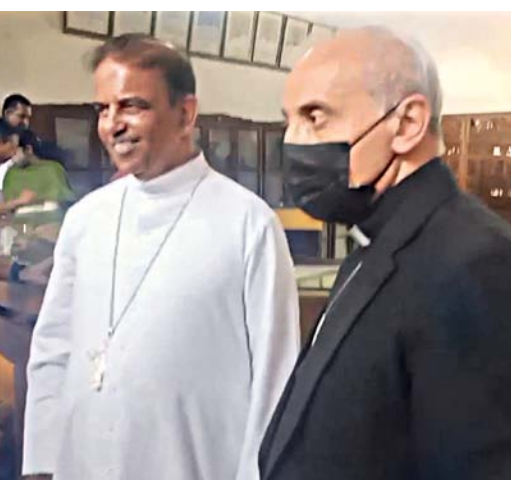
This was a climactic moment in a long protest. The mahants had approached Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi in October, who in turn asked Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot to notify the hills, part of the Braj Chaurasi Kos Parikrama in the Krishna circuit, as a forest. The CM had ordered that a ban on mining be worked out immediately. "We have already decided to ban all mining around the holy hills. The immolation was totally uncalled for. It is saddening," Gehlot said after he met a delegation of mahants from Bharatpur on July 31.

The seers say the October directive, ironically, worsened things: the pace of mining shot up because the miners wanted to make the most of it before the ban. "They have been mining at a very accelerated pace, threatening the ecosystem and the very sanctity of the pilgrimage," a spokesperson for the saints said.

But even as their impatience was growing, the Bharatpur administration threatened the protesters with police cases. Their representatives have also lodged a complaint against mines minister Pramod Jain Bhaya; MoS education Zahida Khan, whose family they accuse of having a stake in the mining, a charge she denies; additional chief secretary, mines, Subodh Agarwal; and mine operator Prabhu Dayal Soni. They were accused of conniving to delay the issue of the notification. The police refused to register an FIR, saying there is already a case against the mining and the immolation.

The core demand is two decades old, and officialdom has been responsive, even if patchily. As BJP CM, Vasundhara Raje banned mining within half a kilometre of the hills in 2005. A subsequent committee recommended a more specific ban in 2007. In 2012, the district magistrate too earmarked the two hills for a ban after a 2009 notification left them out.

The BJP rushed a team to Bharatpur after the immolation; it submitted its report to home minister Amit Shah and sought a CBI probe on July 27. An upset Gehlot called it opportunism, saying, "The BJP rushes in wherever it smells religion." But there are rumblings within the Congress too, with ex-minister and veteran MLA Bharat Singh saying, "Our mines minister is a mining mafia." He accuses Bhaya of facilitating mining in Sorsan in Baran district, where there is a plan to reintroduce the Great Indian Bustard. He asked Gehlot if he should also immolate himself. Bhaya has denied the charge. But there is no dousing the fire. ■



EXIT ORDER Vatican representative in Delhi, Leopoldo Girelli, with archbishop Antony Kariyil in Kochi, July 26

KERALA

A MESS OVER HOLY MASS

By Jeemon Jacob

The venerable Syro-Malabar Church in Kerala, the oldest in the land, has a revolt on its hands with a section of the clergy and laity up in arms over the enforcing of a uniform liturgical code. The issue is over the diktats set by the church on how the Holy Mass must be conducted—essentially which way the priest faces, the altar or the faithful, during the many parts of the ceremony. The issue has created such a hullabaloo that the Vatican, on July 26, asked Antony Kariyil, the archbishop of the Ernakulam-Angamaly archdiocese, to step down for supporting the naysayers. Archbishop Andrews Thazhathu was appointed in his place on June 30.

Kariyil, a social scientist and former principal of Christ College, Bengaluru, had been promoted to archbishop in August 2019 and brought to Ernakulam when another